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Not All Clicks are Created Equal in PPC Advertising



By **Chaz Wilke**, Staff Writer
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We've all heard the term pay per click. We know PPC is one of the most popular forms of online advertising. We know that [advertising makes up 97%](#) of the revenue for Google, the majority of that from AdWords. But what goes into defining a click? Are all clicks created equal? And how are marketers safeguarding click spam or malicious clicks from competitors?

Let's find out.

Advertising has been around for thousands of years. Some of the earliest examples are [political ads](#) found in Pompeii's ruins dating back before the eruption of Mount Vesuvius in 79 AD.

Ever since advertising began, marketers used a spray and pray method. Without upfront distribution metrics, advertisers were forced to rely on projections. Even within the imprecise projections, advertisers were unable to get much postmortem feedback on the digestion of their advertisement. This resulted in much more guessing than the modern digital age of marketing.

In time, we got smarter about it. We studied our target audience's interests, personality, values and opinions, among other factors. We tailored our sales pitches to the right magazines, the right radio shows and the right evening television programs.



All that marketers could estimate is how many people would see the issue with their advertisement or the episode with their commercial. Marketers would then pay upfront for space to run their message. But marketers were at a loss if they wanted to truly know who would see, hear and act on their advertisement.

PPC advertising uses the Internet's capacity to provide marketers with instant customer data. Now, marketers can track visitor engagement in real time, and a PPC ad's cost is based on the number of prospects who click on the ad.

This sounds like the perfect system, but it requires much attention and oversight. Case in point, what if a malicious competitor clicks on your ad knowing that click will cost you money? You'll pay your ad network a lot for certain keywords for PPC campaigns, and each click will be costly. "Insurance" ranks the highest, at [\\$54.91 as of July 2011](#).

And as [Rachael Cihlar on trada.com](#) explains, "Click fraud is a criminal offense, but it can be difficult to prove and expensive to prosecute, because it's often tough to distinguish legitimate from fake clicks." So, what protects your ad from the potential of soaking up your whole marketing budget through potentially fraudulent clicks?

Who Clicks?

WordStream pulled together some [interesting statistics](#) on Google's AdWords, citing that, "Clicks on paid search listings beat out organic clicks by nearly a 2:1 margin for keywords with high commercial intent in the US."

This means that people searching for something like "Buy Flatscreen TV" are 64.6% more likely to click on an AdWords PPC ad than an organic search result.

This is important for two reasons. First, the people generally clicking on these PPC ads already have signaled buying intent through the search query. And second, people doing navigational or informational searches are less likely to click on your ad, which keeps your costs lower.

PPC Click Fraud Countermeasures

So while we've seen direct correlation to those seeking to buy and those clicking on your ads, what can you do to thwart those merely looking to exhaust your marketing budget?



- IP Exclusions

As a marketer, it is your job to keep a mindful eye on your PPC ad campaign's analytic data. IP Exclusions work when you've spotted specific IPs draining your click budget. If you find a certain IP is costing you big chunks of your budget, consider blocking it.

Google recommends this route for more than just preventing malicious activity on your dime. You might also want to [exclude your own company's network](#) to prevent accidental and unwanted clicks from within your walls.

- Geo-Exclusions

Another way to prevent unwanted PPC traffic is to institute geo-exclusions. Targeting specific regions of the country or world where you want your ad to appear, while excluding others, is smart regardless of the added benefit of restricting malicious activity with your ads.

"[Don't target the entire United States](#) if you are just trying to get new customers at a local hair salon in Santa Monica," says LookSmart.

- WordPress Plugins for Affiliates

If you're running an affiliate marketing program on your WordPress site, you can [add plugins](#) to help monitor your visitors' clicks. This helps prevent malicious clicks from bots and humans, as well as clicks from friends attempting to "help."

Taking measures to prevent fraudulent clicks helps keep you from getting banned from the AdSense program. This, in turn, helps keep the paychecks coming for affiliate marketers.

- Switching from CPC to CPM to CPA

Perhaps the largest change you could make as an advertiser to combat click fraud would be to change the method in which you get charged for your ads.

- o CPC (Cost per Click): This is the basic, nearly synonymous PPC pricing model, where PPC is the method of payment, CPC relates to the specific cost of each click. This method relates directly to users clicking on your ad.

- o CPI (Cost per Impression): This pricing model relates to the number of users who've seen your ad and not specifically those who have clicked on it. Generally, this method breaks down into a cost per thousand impressions.

- o CPA (Cost per Action): Depending on your situation, this may be your most optimal method to advertise online. This form requires that you pay only when visitors perform a specific action (fill out a form, purchase a product, etc.), which might help curb malicious clicks on its own.

It should be noted that CPC and CPI do not require additional setup on Google's AdWords program, but CPA will require conversion tracking and Google's conversion optimizer [to be enabled](#) in your account setup.

Takeaway

The path of PPC advertising can be filled with potholes and dead ends, but it seems PPC remains a viable solution for your marketing efforts. There are safeguards available to help prevent malicious clicks, but remember that your mileage may vary.

If you realize you were a click fraud victim, you may still be able to recoup losses. Spamlaws.com explains, "If you can prove the pay per click fraud has been committed, you can receive a refund for the added clicks from your pay per click search engine provider."

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Hailing from Chicago and a product of the Illinois public school system, Chaz Wilke is a professional writer who has written for newspaper, TV, radio, video games, blogs, and film. In his spare time, Chaz enjoys hiking and discovering the hidden gems and oddities of Los Angeles. He also juggles.

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